

sleep deprived but determined. The deep boom of artillery fire rends the air and it's the first time I get a sense that I am in the thick of the battle. I ask Lance Corporal Manjula Kariyawasam what he thinks of the LTTE. He says: "They fight well in the beginning but if you show stiff resistance they usually run away."

The helicopter to ferry me back lands at a nearby field and when we board we find that our companions are three young soldiers, all nursing gory wounds and one lying on the floor of the chopper. Just as we settle down, the pilot asks us to get off. Two soldiers had been grievously injured and they have been ordered to pick them up as well. In five minutes, the chopper is back with the injured personnel and it is a disturbing sight. Two of them, whom I just talked to, lie on the floor badly injured. One of them had his left leg blown away after step-

Under Rajapakse's leadership, the Sri Lankan Government has made substantial progress in the conduct of the war. Much of it has to do with the decisive political will and the unwavering support to the armed forces. What has helped is that by appointing his brother Gotabhaya as the defence secretary, there has been a rare unanimity of tactics and clarity of purpose. This has seen the Sri Lankan armed forces take the Eastern province last year after successfully winning over Karuna, Prabhakaran's former military commander, who joined forces with them to put the LTTE on the run. The Government then held provincial elections in the East in May and Sivanesanathurai Santhirakanthan alias Pillayan, a former LTTE child soldier and political leader who defected along with Karuna, emerged as the chief minister. Meanwhile, Karuna was rewarded with a seat in Parliament under the nominated category. (See accompanying story)

Having secured the East and loosened the stranglehold the Tigers had in Mannar in the West, the Sri Lankan armed forces have restricted the LTTE's writ to two major provinces in the North, Kilinochchi and Mullaitivu, the vital port town that the Sea Tigers use as a base. Showing that they are still a formidable force to reckon with, the Tigers have put up stiff resistance in these two districts and then counter-attacked with terror strikes and air raids over Colombo. The LTTE is said to have two light aircraft which they

use with tremendous psychological advantage. On October 28, the aircraft evaded radar detection and dropped a couple of bombs over Colombo resulting in a blackout for an hour.

Despite these strikes, experts agree that the LTTE is in a bad shape. Intercepts of their wireless communications show them urging their cadres to stay on and battle it out. With the Government's intelligence proving to be good, they have been able to strike decisively at key LTTE leaders even killing their political chief Thamilselvan recently. Prabhakaran, who is on the run has withdrawn reportedly to the jungles around Puthukkudiyiruppu using the two lakh Tamil refugees as a human shield against Sri Lankan air raids. Other experts though believe that the LTTE still has the capability of bouncing back and the Sri Lankan Army is being overstretched and would be bogged down in Wanni.



UPPER HAND: Sri Lankan troops display captured LTTE firepower

ping on a mine and also lost his right eye. He lay on the floor with a drip bottle, blood still oozing from his wound. The other had pellet marks all over his body and his leg muscles seemed to have been destroyed. We completed the journey back to base in pensive silence.

This is a war where no mercy is asked or given. Already, over 10,000 Tigers have been killed in the fighting in the past two years—reducing their strength of trained personnel to around 5,000. The Sri Lankan Army too has lost over 2,000 of its men, a third of them to mine blasts. It is a fight to finish—a determined battle by the Sri Lankan Government to defeat the LTTE, regain territory and capture Prabhakaran—dead or alive. A day earlier at his residence in Colombo, President Rajapakse told me: "For us this war will be over only when we get Prabhakaran and his key deputies." (See interview)